

TREE & SERPENT
Early Buddhist Art in India
By John Guy
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At the heart of the *Tree & Serpent* exhibition showcasing early Buddhist art in India from 200 BCE to 400 CE at the Metropolitan Museum in New York are sections of a monument so stunning they're worth the price of entry all by themselves. Soaring above the visitor are whitened limestone fragments of a monumental gateway—a *torana*—bookended by expressive composite animal creatures: lions, elephants and griffins, each topped by a rider and fused to toothy open-mouthed *makaras*, mythic sea creatures with lolling tongues. Between their jaws unfurl exquisitely carved panels depicting episodes from the Buddha's biography.

These ancient treasures were only recently disinterred during a 2003 excavation in Phanigiri, a "snake-hooded hill" monastery complex that flourished in modern-day Telangana between the 3rd and 4th centuries. Coming to the exhibition "direct from the godown under the management of Telangana State Archaeology Museum", they represent just a few of the over 125 relics on view until November 13 in New York, and represent, according to the Met's curator of South and Southeast Asian Art John Guy, "the largest exhibition of antiquities to come out of India in a generation".

While these antiquities comprise "quite a constellation of star objects", including many on loan from six state governments, Guy's objective was explicitly to shine a light on lesser-known luminaries of ancient Buddhist art. "We had no interest in doing an A-Z of Indian Buddhism, the standard repertoire of Buddhist objects," he says. The exhibition aimed to "shift the paradigm" away from the usual focus on holy sites visited by the Buddha during his lifetime, focusing instead on the monasteries of the Satavahana and Ikṣvāku kingdoms of the south, in coastal Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Karnataka and Maharashtra, where Buddhism flourished in the centuries following the Buddha's death. "It's great art that should be in the corpus of Buddhist art globally, but is largely overlooked," he adds.

This neglect is, for the most part, something of an art-historical holdover. The earliest archaeological documentations and excavations of ancient Buddhist sites in India were carried out in the mid-19th century by British army officers such as Frederick Charles Maisey and Alexander Cunningham, with the latter becoming the first Director-General of the Archaeological Survey of India. "Cunningham didn't travel south beyond the Vindhyas on his surveys and, as was to be expected, focused on Buddhist sites in north India," says archaeologist and scholar Himanshu Prabha Ray, who contributed an essay to the exhibition's sumptuous catalogue (published by Mapin in India). "Nonetheless, the impact of his voluminous reports and writings about sites associated with the Buddha in north India has continued into the present."



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The exhibition casts a long-due spotlight on the ancient Buddhist sites of the Deccan, bringing into view their distinctive sculptural features, and economic and sociocultural context. It also brings to life the experience of the monks and devotees who frequented the stupa complexes of the Deccan, many of which, Ray points out, are distinguished from their central Indian counterparts by their marked maritime orientation along the coast, and their interlinkages with Buddhist communities in Sri Lanka, Myanmar and Thailand. (The maritime trade also explains the sumptuousness of these sites, with their monumental gateways and distinctive "āyāka" platforms, on which rested relics, offerings and, later, images of the Buddha.)

Possibly the most striking feature of early Buddhist art, particularly in southern sites, is their emphasis on the twin leit-